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White ethnic majority German young adults' accounts of parental socialization around race, ethnicity, culture, and national identity

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ABSTRACT

As adolescents in Germany grow up amid ethnic diversity and inequity, understanding how white parents use ethnic-racial socialization (ERS) to shape their children's role in reinforcing or challenging inequities is crucial. We explored white ethnic majority German young adults' retrospective accounts of their parental ERS. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with nineteen white, ethnic majority young adults (age range: 19–32, 7 men, 12 women) from different regions in Germany. Through codebook thematic analysis, five themes were developed: (1) *Perceived culture- and race-less socialization*, (2) *preaching but not practicing egalitarianism*, (3) *distancing from racism*, (4) *social identities and intergroup contact afford diversity and equity socialization*, as well as (5) *youth-directed socialization*. The findings expose a gap between the socialization goals upheld by white, ethnic majority German parents and their application in a dynamically evolving society, and highlight the role of young adults as not just passive receivers, but active agents of ERS.

Germany, like many other countries, has experienced significant demographic changes in recent decades. As the population becomes increasingly culturally and ethnically diverse, it is essential to explore how different cultural, ethnic, or racialized groups navigate their identities and engage with continuing social inequities within this shifting landscape. Whereas culturally, ethnically, or racially minoritized groups must contend with systemic inequities and discrimination, white individuals often benefit from and contribute to these hierarchies, whether consciously or unconsciously (Moffitt & Rogers, 2022). Families are important socialization contexts for children and adolescents (Bronfenbrenner, 2005) and can contribute to the development of beliefs and behaviors regarding cultural, ethnic, and racialized identities and corresponding social hierarchies (Aral et al., 2022; García Coll et al., 1996; Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024).

To this end, families engage in ethnic-racial socialization (ERS), a “dynamic and multifaceted social,

cognitive, and developmental process through which ideas, beliefs, values, social norms, and behaviors regarding race and ethnicity are transmitted, interpreted, negotiated, and adopted” (Loyd & Gaither, 2018, p. 6). Whereas ERS research has primarily centered on ethnically and racially minoritized families in the U.S., recently, research has increasingly examined ERS in white families (Loyd & Gaither, 2018; Nieri et al., 2024) and has started studying ERS in contexts outside of the U.S. (de Bruijn et al., 2025; Dimitrova et al., 2018; Kaiser et al., 2025, 2024; Mesman et al., 2022; Štambuk et al., 2020; van Bergen et al., 2017).

Our study builds onto this research and explores how white, ethnic majority young adults in Germany recount their parental socialization regarding race, ethnicity, culture, and national identity. It examines parental ERS in a context in which the concept of “Rasse”¹ nowadays is largely taboo (Juang et al., 2021), and public discourses on diversity instead focus on the intertwined concepts of ethnicity, culture, and

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¹We use the German term “Rasse” when referring to German discourse regarding this particular term. The German term “Rasse” carries strong biologicistic connotations, reinforced by its historical use in Nazi ideology, as well as its application to animal breeds. In contrast, English distinguishes between “race” (for humans) and “breed” (for animals). Due to these problematic connotations, some German-speaking scholars and activists prefer to use the English term “race” to emphasize its socially constructed nature (poco.lit, 2021). Accordingly, we use “race” when we connect to broader or international discussions that view race as a social construct.

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national belonging (Ditlmann & Kopf-Beck, 2019). However, not discussing existing racism risks obscuring the enduring legacy of white supremacy, as well as exclusionary ethnic-cultural notions of national belonging in Germany. By examining parental ERS in this context, our study contributes to understanding how white majority families navigate—and potentially reinforce or disrupt—systems of racial privilege and exclusion. By focusing on the young adults' perspective, we acknowledge the multidirectional nature of socialization and capture how youth not only receive, but actively interpret and negotiate parents' socialization messages (Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024). To pursue our research aim, we employ an exploratory approach, based on qualitative interviews and codebook thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

ERS among white families

Traditionally, parent ERS has been studied as a way how ethnically or racially minoritized groups, particularly in the U.S., affirm their own cultural or ethnic identities and prepare their children for life in an unequal society (for reviews, see for example Hughes et al., 2006; Huguley et al., 2019; Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020; Wang et al., 2020). Only recently has ERS in white families, mainly in the U.S., become a focus of research (for reviews, see Aral et al., 2022; Loyd & Gaither, 2018; Nieri et al., 2024; Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024; Priest et al., 2014; Simon, 2021), partly because whiteness, for a long time, has been perceived to represent normative development (Karras et al., 2021).

Because white families occupy a structurally privileged position within a society shaped by white supremacy, their experiences with ethnicity and race are not defined by systemic racial discrimination. Thus, ERS is quantitatively and qualitatively different in this group and serves different functions. For example, whereas preparation for (racial) bias (i.e. messages preparing children or adolescents for prejudice and discrimination) is common among ethnically or racially minoritized groups (Hughes et al., 2006; Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020), white families, benefiting from systemic racism and the normalization of whiteness, are often afforded the privilege to not see themselves in terms of race and to avoid discussing the topic of racism (Applebaum, 2016; Essed & Trienekens, 2008; Loyd & Gaither, 2018).

Accordingly, the most prevalent ERS strategies observed among white families are racial silence and color-evasive as well as power-evasive socialization, i.e. ignoring or downplaying group differences and

racism (Hamm, 2001; Loyd & Gaither, 2018; Mounts et al., 2013; Pahlke et al., 2021; Underhill, 2019; Vittrup, 2018; Zucker & Patterson, 2018). Many white parents argue that the topic of race just did not come up (Vittrup, 2018), but also ignore or redirect conversations about race when it is salient in children's books (Pahlke et al., 2012) or when they are explicitly instructed to discuss race with their children (Vittrup & Holden, 2011). Despite many white parents' belief that avoiding ethnic-racial issues will reduce racist attitudes among their children, ignoring racism does uphold racial inequality (Hagerman, 2014; Hazelbaker et al., 2022).

Some parents, however, particularly mothers (Kincaid & Underhill, 2024), do engage in color-conscious socialization, supporting children's awareness of and resistance to racism (Abaied et al., 2022; Abaied & Perry, 2021; Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022). Color-conscious socialization is associated with positive intergroup outcomes among white children, such as more positive intergroup attitudes (Vittrup & Holden, 2011) and reduced pro-white biases (Perry, Wu, et al., 2024). Recent findings from the Netherlands suggest that these findings also translate to other societal contexts (Mesman et al., 2022).

Besides avoiding discussing race and racism, white families tend to engage in little explicit cultural socialization (i.e. messages that promote cultural pride or convey an understanding of one's cultural origin), unlike ethnically or racially minoritized families (Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). As whiteness is typically perceived as normative (Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024), white families can engage in unnamed cultural practices (Loyd & Gaither, 2018) and tend to perceive that only others "have a culture" (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022).

Many of white parents' explicit ERS practices focus on promoting positive intergroup relations through egalitarian or diversity socialization (Aral et al., 2022; Loyd & Gaither, 2018; Simon, 2021). Egalitarian ERS strategies, for example, convey that all people are equal regardless of their skin color, that it is important to appreciate people of all cultural, ethnic, or racialized groups (Pahlke et al., 2021; Zucker & Patterson, 2018) or that children should become good people who see "people as people" (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022). Whereas a focus on egalitarianism may have benefits, it can be problematic if it is rooted in a color-evasive perspective that minimizes or ignores racism (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022). Some white parents also engage in diversity socialization by teaching their kids to accept and value diversity (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022),

exposing them to peers with different backgrounds (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022; Underhill, 2019), or by having a diverse friend network themselves (Loyd & Gaither, 2018). However, if diversity socialization emphasizes kindness and tolerance without addressing deeper structural issues, it may prove insufficient or even counterproductive in tackling systemic inequities (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022).

Negotiating race, ethnicity, culture, and national belonging in the German context

Limited research has focused on ethnic majority, white parent ERS outside the U.S. (for exceptions, see de Bruijn et al., 2025; Kaiser et al., 2025, 2024; Mesman et al., 2022). Understanding sociocultural and historical contexts, which also entail differential meanings of concepts such as “race,” is crucial for understanding ERS processes (Juang et al., 2021). Whereas “race” is typically understood as a social construct by scholars (Karras et al., 2021), beliefs about race as a biologically rooted category persist in the U.S. and elsewhere, including Germany. The German term “Rasse” in particular is strongly associated with biologicistic ideas from the Nazi racial ideology, which framed “Rasse” as a biological hierarchy used to justify genocide. Jews, Roma and Sinti, Black people, and others were racialized through pseudo-scientific criteria like physical features and ancestry. Post-WWII, the term “Rasse” has largely been avoided in public discourse to distance Germany from its Nazi past (Juang et al., 2021; Jugert et al., 2021; Roig, 2017). Racism is typically discussed in the context of the Holocaust, with less focus on colonialism or contemporary subtle and structural forms of racism (Federal Government Expert Commission on the Framework for Sustainable Integration, 2021). However, recent efforts aim to increase public and academic attention to the persistent, often overlooked manifestations of subtle and structural racism (DeZIM, 2023).

Public debates on diversity in contemporary Germany center on migration status, culture, ethnicity, and national belonging. Germany's historical *jus sanguinis* (citizenship by bloodline) reinforced conflation of German ethnic and national identity, and even after *jus soli* (birthright citizenship) reforms, “being German” is often understood as a cultural-ethnic label, assigning those who are perceived to be “culturally or ethnically German” the dominant social position usually associated with whiteness. Access to national identity is denied for people of “migrant

background” (Canan & Foroutan, 2016; Dittmann & Kopf-Beck, 2019), a term which has become racialized, referring to anyone perceived as having non-German ancestry, such as those of Turkish or Arab descent, Muslims, and other People of Color (Moffitt & Juang, 2019). Thus, contemporary racism in Germany is often expressed through the binary distinction between a socially constructed natio-ethno-cultural “we” and the “others” perceived to not belong to this group (Mecheril, 2002; Scharathow, 2017).

For some white, ethnic majority German adolescents, their privileged position and unquestioned “Germanness,” combined with the history of the Holocaust and transgenerational guilt, complicate the development of a national identity (Seiffge-Krenke & Haid, 2012). Due to the country's historical legacy, national identity is a contested and politically charged concept, and many white Germans distance themselves from explicit nationalist expressions. In contrast, those Germans perceived to be of “migrant background” are often expected to prove their belonging to Germany. Thus, rather than challenging exclusionary understandings of Germanness, Germany's reckoning with its past can sometimes reinforce an ingroup that implicitly excludes those without white ethnic majority German ancestry (Moffitt et al., 2018). Taboos surrounding the concept of “Rasse,” cultural-ethnic notions of Germanness, and a contested national identity may all shape how parental ERS manifests in the German context.

As two of the first studies examining white, ethnic majority parent ERS in Germany, Kaiser et al. (2025, 2024) conducted interviews with parents of elementary school children in two contexts with low (in East Germany) and high (in West Germany) ethnic diversity. Parents largely maintained silence about race and a color-evasive approach, even though parents in the highly diverse context were less hesitant to label diversity and to recognize their whiteness. Parents' messages on diversity and equality in both contexts were vague and often superficial, with some parents promoting stereotypes and mistrust. Especially in the low diverse context, parents felt insecure and hesitant discussing diversity and racism. Our current research complements Kaiser et al.'s research by not examining the parents', but the young adults' perspective on their parental ERS.

ERS from the perspective of young adults

ERS is a dynamic, lifelong process that evolves across developmental stages and contexts (Hughes et al.,

2006; Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). Adolescence and young adulthood are particularly salient periods for ERS, as individuals engage in more complex exploration and meaning-making about their ethnic-racial identities, which includes reflecting on societal and familial messages about race and ethnicity (Umaña-Taylor et al., 2014). This developmental period is characterized by increased cognitive maturity, enabling young people to critically engage with and reinterpret earlier socialization experiences as they form their own worldviews. Thus ERS during adolescence and young adulthood in particular is not a mechanical “top-down process,” but a dynamic interaction between an individual and the environment (Hagerman, 2016; Hurrelmann, 2012; Perry et al., 2024). For example, adolescents and young adults may prompt parents to share information regarding race or ethnicity, may disagree with their parents’ messages, and may even actively shape their caregivers’ racial understanding (Hagerman, 2022; Hughes et al., 2006; Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024). This active engagement positions young adults not only as active agents of their own socialization, but as individuals who negotiate their roles in either perpetuating or challenging racial inequities.

The present study

This study explored how white, ethnic majority German young adults recount their parents’ socialization with regards to race, ethnicity, culture, and national identity. We conducted semi-structured interviews with young adults from various regions in Germany. By focusing on young adults’ retrospective accounts of their parents’ ERS, we acknowledge the interactive nature of socialization processes (Hagerman, 2016; Hurrelmann, 2012; Perry et al., 2024) and gain insights into how messages regarding race and ethnicity are not just transmitted, but are “interpreted, negotiated, and adopted” (Loyd & Gaither, 2018, p. 6). In addition, examining young adults’ retrospective accounts allows us to understand how ERS dynamically interacts with broader societal changes and developmental transitions.

As racism in Germany is often expressed through negotiations of natio-ethno-cultural belongings (Mecheril, 2002; Scharathow, 2017), we did not just capture young adults’ accounts of socialization with regards to race and racism, but also to ethnicity, culture, and national identity. We expected to find themes that overlap with previous U.S.-and Germany-based research, such as a strong focus on racial silence

and color-evasion, (shallow) egalitarianism, or diversity socialization. However, we also expected to find new themes specific to the sociocultural context and to the young adults’ perspective on their parents’ ERS.

Materials and methods

Participants and procedure

After receiving ethical approval from the university ethics committee, participants were recruited through criterion and snowball sampling (Patton, 2002). Flyers on social media and university listservs informed participants that we wanted to learn about their experiences of growing up in Germany, with inclusion criteria (a) being between 18 and 32 years, (b) having no children of one’s own and (c) having themselves and both parents grown up in Germany. A brief screening questionnaire ensured participants fit our inclusion criteria. Initial participants were asked to recruit further participants, resulting in 19 participants between 19 and 32 years old ($M_{\text{age}} = 25.47$, $SD_{\text{age}} = 4.16$). The majority (63%; $N = 12$) identified as women and 37% ($N = 7$) identified as men. Due to taboos surrounding the concept of race in Germany, race is typically not assessed in surveys in this context. Instead, we asked participants for their cultural/ethnic self-identification. Five of the participants listed “white” as part of their cultural/ethnic self-identification, other identifications included, for example, “German,” “European,” or regional identities. Participants came from various urban and rural regions in Germany (see Table 1 for details).

After participants received an information sheet and signed an informed consent form, interviews were conducted between December 2021 and April 2022 by the first author via Zoom, due to the COVID-19 pandemic and the diverse geographic location of participants. Participants chose pseudonyms for use in the interviews and the present paper. Interviews (lasting between 48 and 106 min) were semi-structured based on an interview guide, comprising questions addressing aspects of white ERS identified in previous research, as well as topics relevant to ERS in Germany (e.g., Holocaust socialization) (for a list of main interview questions, see [Supplementary Materials S1](#)). Room was given to explore additional topics brought up by participants themselves. At the end of the interviews, participants completed a demographic questionnaire and received a 30€ gift certificate.

Table 1. Participant characteristics.

Pseudonym	Age	Gender identity	Highest educational degree of interviewee	Highest educational degree of first parent	Highest educational degree of second parent	Grew up in ... ^a	Cultural/Ethnic self-identification
Franziska	32	Woman	Master's degree	Bachelor's degree	Doctorate	Western Germany	White
Joana	30	Woman	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Eastern Germany	–
Sabine	31	Woman	Master's degree	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	–
Michael	32	Man	Master's degree	Master craftsman	Abitur ^b	Western Germany	White, European
Saskia	29	Woman	Bachelor's degree	Diploma	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	White, Central European
Abigail	23	Woman	Abitur ^b	Bachelor's degree	Apprenticeship	Eastern Germany	German
Frieda	23	Woman	Bachelor's degree	Apprenticeship	Bachelor's degree	Western Germany	–
Carola	29	Woman	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	German
Flora	21	Woman	Abitur ^b	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	German
Mia	20	Woman	Abitur ^b	Abitur ^b	Apprenticeship	Eastern Germany	European, German
Sett	22	Man	Abitur ^b	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	White, German, Human
Yannick	26	Man	Abitur ^b	Master's degree	Master's degree	Western Germany	Western European, White, Regional Identity ^a
Max	25	Man	Bachelor's degree	Master's degree	Bachelor's degree	Western Germany	–
Jana	25	Woman	Bachelor's degree	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	Religious groups, students
Benjamin	23	Man	Bachelor's degree	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	European
Maximilian	28	Man	Master's degree	Apprenticeship	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	Western cultural space, Europe, German society
Lou	21	Woman	Abitur ^b	Secondary School (Vocational School Degree)	Technical diploma	Western Germany	Regional identity, Christian, German
Tim	19	Man	Abitur ^b	–	–	Western Germany	German
Lena	25	Woman	Bachelor's degree	Master's degree	Apprenticeship	Western Germany	–

Note.^aSpecific region is not provided here for pseudonymization purposes; ^bAbitur = degree offered at the end of secondary education in Germany, after 12 or 13 years of schooling, which allows access to university-level education.

Positionality

The first author is a white, ethnic majority German cis-woman who grew up in an ethnically and racially homogeneous environment, but has since lived in ethnically and racially diverse, urban environments and multiple countries. This background provided both an insider and outsider perspective on white parent ERS, allowing for a deep understanding of participants' lived experiences, as well as for reflections on the particularities of white German ERS from an international perspective. The second and third authors are cis-women and first-generation immigrants from Turkey and the U.S. and have lived in Germany for 7 to 15 years. They conducted comparable studies on ERS among ethnically and racially minoritized groups in Germany (Aral & Juang, 2025). These studies were drawn on to critically compare and interrogate interpretations, ensuring that findings emerged not from a single viewpoint (e.g., based on the first author's own experiences of white parent ERS), but through an intersubjective process of meaning-making. The first

author became a parent during the data analysis of this article, the third author is a parent of two teenagers.

All authors have backgrounds in quantitative psychological research, leading us to use “codebook thematic analysis” rather than reflexive thematic analysis. Codebook thematic analysis, referred to as a “small q” approach, follows a structured coding framework for consistency, whereas reflexive thematic analysis, referred to as a “big Q” approach, prioritizes flexibility and evolving interpretations (Braun & Clarke, 2022). Thus, we opted for a structured approach using a codebook to align with our methodological orientation.

Coding and analysis

Interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed by a trained student assistant. Transcripts were shared with participants for feedback, with only two participants requesting minor wording changes. We used

codebook thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022), following six analytic phases (Braun & Clarke, 2021). After familiarizing ourselves with the data, the first and second author and a student assistant developed a codebook and coded the data using MAXQDA 2022 (VERBI Software, 2021). Initial codes were deductively derived from U.S. research on white parent ERS, and German literature on race and racism. These codes were adapted and new ones added inductively from the data throughout the research process, continuously updating the codebook. The aim of the codebook was not to measure intercoder agreement, but to facilitate coordination between several coders (Braun & Clarke, 2022). We prioritized consensus throughout the research process, discussing ambiguous instances between the first and second author as well as the student assistant. Next, initial themes were generated, reviewed, refined, and named, before results were written up. All coding was done in German, excerpts were translated into English for this article.

Results

The following themes were developed, each comprising two subthemes: (1) Perceived culture- and race-less socialization; (2) preaching but not practicing egalitarianism; (3) distancing from racism; (4) social identities and intergroup contact afford diversity and equity socialization; and (5) youth-directed socialization (see Table 2).

“It wasn’t really relevant to discuss the whole issue”—perceived culture- and race-less socialization

Participants reported having learned little about the meaning of being German, being white, and about German culture. Instead of prescribing a specific culture, parents were seen as emphasizing individuality and freedom of choice.

Perceived lack of explicit white German cultural/ethnic/racial socialization

Many participants reported never having talked with their parents about what “being German” means. As members of the cultural and ethnic majority, participants rarely faced questioning of their “Germanness” and perceived their identity as the norm, resulting in a perceived lack of necessity to initiate discussions about it. Michael explained:

It certainly wasn’t a taboo subject or anything, but it wasn’t really relevant to discuss the whole issue

either. For me personally, it was a topic that was just accepted. There were no disadvantages to accepting it as it was. [...] Because the comparison was missing.

Thus, the privileges of belonging to the cultural and ethnic majority group, along with a lack of close interethnic contact, led to their own group being perceived as the mainstream and not being a focus of explicit parental socialization processes. Similarly, only two of the participants recalled their parents encouraging reflections on their own social positioning as being white, without explicitly naming whiteness but rather stressing they may be treated better because of their “looks.” The reluctance to discuss whiteness may be traced back to the taboo surrounding the concept of “Rasse” in German discourse and its association with the Holocaust. However, it also means that the implicit equation of “Germanness” with being white was rarely ever put into question. This mirrors “white normativity socialization” observed in previous qualitative research on parent ERS in Germany (Kaiser et al., 2025, 2024).

Many participants initially struggled answering how their parents conveyed German culture to them and a few even expressed regret regarding their perceived lack of heritage cultural socialization. The struggle to describe German culture socialization was rooted in difficulties defining “German culture.” The only aspect participants rather uniformly identified as being part of German culture socialization was celebrating traditions such as Christmas or Easter, highlighting an understanding of “Germanness” limited to one specific cultural or religious heritage. Other than that, participants’ understanding of German culture showed large variations, for example between regions (e.g., speaking specific dialects, eating regional foods, celebrating regional festivals) and between East and West Germany. For example, parents who grew up in the former German Democratic Republic were recalled to stress good childcare and women in the workforce as an East German value, in comparison to West Germany. The large variety of examples provided for cultural socialization suggests that what participants perceived as “culture-less” socialization may reflect a lack of explicit engagement with a unified “German culture” rather than an absence of cultural influences altogether.

Focus on individualism

Participants frequently pointed out that their parents did not enforce specific cultural or religious practices, but instead highlighted the importance of

Table 2. Overview of themes.

Theme	Subtheme	Description	Example quote
Perceived culture- and race-less socialization	Perceived lack of explicit white German cultural/ethnic/racial socialization	- No conversations with parents about the meaning of “being German” or whiteness - Own cultural/ethnic/racial group perceived as the mainstream - Perceived lack of cultural socialization rooted in difficulties defining “German culture”	“So in my family, being German was never really a topic. Of course, we were told things from history and so on by our grandparents. Which has to do with German history. But otherwise it wasn’t really a big topic.” (Carola)
	Focus on individualism	Parents highlighting individualism, own responsibility, and freedom of choice	“Because I realized that other cultures really place a lot of value on these customs, but my parents taught me more about these interpersonal things and also a bit about these traditions, but at some point, when I was a certain age, my parents also said: You’re old enough, you can do it the way you want from now on.” (Sett)
Preaching but not practicing egalitarianism	(Assumed) egalitarian goals	- Parents perceived to want their children to treat all other human beings equally and to not endorse prejudice - Sometimes mixed with color-evasion	“[...] we are now back to the implicit values that were communicated. It was important to them that [...] I didn’t hate foreigners and that I love my neighbors, but then really everyone and not just fellow Germans and things like that.” (Michael)
	Promotion of mistrust	- Parents having few intercultural or interethnic friendships - Parents promoting mistrust through ways deemed socially acceptable, such as cultural racism and endorsing ethnic-cultural notions of “Germanness”	“My sister also had a Greek boyfriend for a while and a Turkish boyfriend, an Iranian boyfriend. [...] And that was or is rather problematized. [...] my parents assumed that this is somehow not the right thing for my sister.” (Maximilian)
Distancing from racism	“Bystander” Holocaust socialization	- Parents encouraging general learning about and from the Holocaust - Little discussion of own ancestors’ active role in the Holocaust	“No, I don’t think we talked about that at all. So about our family, (.), for example, I don’t even know which of my grandfathers, I think they both fought in the war, although then I would have to count back how old they were. [...] but apart from that, my one grandma, for example, wasn’t even that old at the time. Ah yes, my grandma told us, for example, that she also witnessed the bombs falling.” (Tim)
	Lack of socialization about modern, everyday racism	- Parents condemning explicit (right-wing) forms of racism or racist incidents happening abroad - Parents rarely discussing modern everyday racism in Germany, with few exceptions	“Yes, I’m sure we talked about it at the dinner table in the evening. I can’t think of a specific example now. But I do know, for example, that my parents always expressed quite a lot of disapproval of that kind of thing. [...] So yes, to radical forms of right-wing extremism and things like that.” (Tim)
Social identities & intergroup contact afford diversity and equity socialization	Minoritized social identities promote diversity and equity socialization	- Parents engaging in diversity and equity socialization with regards to other, minoritized social identities - Own experiences of discrimination sometimes translated into increased empathy for outgroup members	“[...] my grandparents were actually also refugees. [...] And they never felt welcome, which is very interesting. Yes, they never felt welcome and in Swabian they also say ‘Neigschmeckte’. So ‘Reingeschmeckte’, who just don’t come from there.” (Sabine)
	Intergroup contact promotes diversity and equity socialization	- Growing up in homogeneous environment related to little diversity and equity socialization - Diversity in the neighborhood or parents’ workplace promoting parental diversity and equity socialization	“I think they always wanted me to be open, to have as few prejudices as possible. But that was also somehow difficult for us. Because we simply had little or no contact. Sure, now and again in the city, but

(Continued)

Table 2. Continued.

Theme	Subtheme	Description	Example quote
Youth-directed socialization	Young adults initiating conversations about modern, everyday racism	• Young adults initiating discussions on modern, everyday racism with parents • Young adults' own awareness of racism and discrimination only developing recently in changed societal climate	you only see people there and don't have any direct contact." (Frieda) "I also talk a lot about anti-Muslim racism. Yes, we do talk about that. But I think that's often initiated by me. So I don't know if it's the other way round." (Sabine)
	Parental insecurity in a changing society	• Parents expressing insecurity regarding discussing and addressing racism • Young adults highlighting generational gaps	"But we've both come to a consensus that the language is changing and that she can accept what I say more and that I remember that it was different and that maybe you have to communicate it in a certain way and not say it directly: That's another bad word you've said." (Saskia)

individuality, own responsibility, and freedom of choice. As Max describes:

As far as culture and religion are concerned - very little was prescribed. It was, yes, in the sense of, I can see for myself what I like, where I want to go, and there were no barriers and no guidance in that sense.

Even though the parents' focus on individuality and freedom of choice was perceived as a lack of heritage culture socialization, it may represent heritage culture socialization in terms of how self-actualization and self-expression are emphasized across cultures (Markus & Kitayama, 1991). Moreover, the families' privileged position as white, ethnic majority Germans may have given them the freedom to be seen as individuals as opposed to members of a certain cultural or ethnic group, and to emphasize individualism as a socialization goal.

"I do believe that they wanted me to be open"—preaching but not practicing egalitarianism

Egalitarian messages were among the most frequent parent ERS messages recalled by our participants, though they contradicted parents' actual practices, which often promoted mistrust and "othering." This shallow focus on egalitarianism mirrors patterns found in other research from the U.S. (Gillen-O'Neel et al., 2022; Underhill, 2018) and Germany (Kaiser et al., 2025, 2024).

(Assumed) egalitarian goals

Most participants recalled that their parents wanted them to treat all other human beings equally regardless of their cultural or ethnic affiliations, to be tolerant and open, and to not endorse prejudice. In some cases this goal was assumed and taken for granted,

rather than explicitly expressed by the parents. For example, Frieda explained:

But, yes, I do believe that they wanted me to be open, that I don't have any fear of contact or prejudices. That I don't make any differences or see differences, although that is of course also, yes, a problem. [...]. But that was never, that was never such a big issue, maybe it's just assumed a little bit.

Frieda reflects on the fact that her parents' focus on "not seeing differences" may also have been problematic. Encouraging children to not see differences may constitute a form of color-evasion, which can go along with ignoring discrimination and structural disadvantages in society (Neville et al., 2000). Some parents also engaged in active diversity socialization. This, however, mostly took place in an international context (e.g., traveling with their children to get to know different cultures), not in the context of a diverse Germany, with few exceptions (e.g., parents deliberately not serving pork when their child brought home a Muslim friend).

Promotion of mistrust

Despite promoting egalitarian values, the same parents often did not practice what they preached. Even though parents were rather uniformly recalled to be open to their children having interethnic friendships, parents' implicit socialization spoke otherwise, as most of them did not have close interethnic friendships themselves. Abigail reflects:

[...] I realized myself that maybe it had something to do with my parents, that they had a very homogeneous circle of friends, and that mine perhaps always remained very homogeneous. Even though they never said they weren't allowed to come home or anything. And everyone is welcome at any time. And I find that very interesting.

Many parents also conveyed explicit messages contradicting their egalitarian goals. Even though they rarely openly promoted racist views or white supremacy, which may also be due to social stigma (similar to parents in the U.S.: Loyd & Gaither, 2018), they did convey messages promoting mistrust through ways currently still (problematically so) deemed more acceptable in many parts of German society. For example, Jana's mother discouraged her from engaging in a relationship with a Muslim person, citing assumed religious incompatibility. This mirrors findings from previous U.S.-based research that found higher parental discomfort with interethnic dating relationships vs. friendships (Edmonds & Killen, 2009), and is also an expression of widespread narratives in Germany in which Muslims are being portrayed as "culturally foreign" and "other" (Kaddor et al., 2018), reflecting notions of cultural racism (Fereidooni & El, 2017). Other participants in our study reported their parents expressing concerns when their children moved to a diverse neighborhood or making racist jokes. The gap between what parents preached (i.e. egalitarianism) and what they practiced (i.e. promoting mistrust) suggests that many white German parents' ERS strategies remain rather superficial, and may fall short of actually contributing to a more egalitarian society.

"Racism is forbidden, therefore we are not racist"—distancing from racism

Participants overwhelmingly recalled their parents only discussing racism as something rather distant from oneself and one's own life. Conversations typically focused on racism during one specific period in history (i.e. the Holocaust), on racism abroad, or in the form of right-wing extremism, but rarely on contemporary, everyday racism.

"Bystander" holocaust socialization

Even though many participants remembered their parents encouraging learning about the Holocaust, e.g., by watching movies together or visiting memorial sites, most reported that their grandparents or parents did not talk much about their own ancestors' role in the Holocaust. If discussed, own family members were typically portrayed as bystanders or victims rather than as perpetrators, e.g., as being held as prisoners of war, or as being against the Nazi regime. Some participants doubted these accounts, e.g., Lena:

I knew that my grandfather had been in the war and then I kind of asked if he had been one of the bad guys. And of course my mother said no, but to be

honest I don't really know. Of course she probably didn't want to get her parents involved, but everyone always says the family didn't do anything, it must have been someone, in the end. They can't all have just looked the other way.

Our participants' accounts are in line with findings from quantitative survey studies, in which only 18% of participants aged 16 and above across Germany believed that their ancestors were among the perpetrators during the second world war (Zick et al., 2018). By framing family history in terms of victimhood or passive bystandership, parents avoid confronting the uncomfortable reality of complicity in systemic racism and genocide. This type of socialization distances contemporary white Germans from the legacy of racial violence.

Some parents conveyed lessons from Germany's history, ranging from emphasizing responsibility for not being racist and for not letting something similar happen again, to explicitly rejecting right-wing or nationalist attitudes, and drawing connections to current-day political developments. For example, Mia recalls:

So that above all this responsibility is very important. That you are aware of what happened. And that you can't just forget about it or distance yourself from it and pretend that it didn't happen. And then of course I think that you also have to think about the education, so to speak: Where does this come from, how can something like this happen? And that's why we watched the film 'The Wave'², for example. And then it was so shocking again, how can something like this happen? That such a dynamic can develop, that there is one person who, for example, leads and many follow. And that's what we really talked about a lot.

Despite the relevance of fostering a remembrance culture around the Holocaust, limiting discussions of racism to a specific period in history ignores that racism already existed before the Nazi era, e.g., as a driving force of German colonialism (Roig, 2017). Importantly, only one participant in our study recalled ever discussing Germany's colonial history with her parents, and this only happened in the context of traveling abroad to Namibia. In addition, the emphasis on the Holocaust as a singular, historical event neglects the continuity of racism in contemporary German society.

²"The Wave" is a 2008 German movie, based on a 1981 U.S. book (Rhee, 1981) telling the story of a history teacher who aims to teach his students about autocracy by starting a real-life experiment showing how easily masses, i.e., the students in his class, can be manipulated.

Lack of socialization about modern, everyday racism

Despite participants' perception that parents aimed to sensitize their children to be anti-racist due to Germany's history, parents rarely addressed modern, everyday racism within Germany. If contemporary racism was discussed, this was limited to condemning explicit forms of racism such as right-wing extremist attacks reported in the news, or racist incidents happening abroad, such as in the U.S. Abigail recalls:

Abigail: Yes, when there was something from America or something in the newspaper. Then they talked about why, why it was so bad. Why it was in the newspaper. And, yes, exactly. How it came about and why we shouldn't treat people the way it happened.

Interviewer: Have you ever talked about racist incidents in Germany?

Abigail: No, actually not at all. Because I don't think I, for example, read about it that much. So of course it could be my fault and my parents' fault ((laughs)). But what I remember is never that it was something in Germany. Although nowadays, of course, we know that it also exists here and a lot.

Similar patterns of distancing oneself from racism by locating it solely in the past, in right-wing extremism, or abroad have been documented by other authors in Germany (Messerschmidt, 2010). These distancing patterns can prevent or overshadow discussing subtle and structural forms of contemporary racism (Messerschmidt, 2010; Roig, 2017). Accordingly, Joana recounted that when conversations touched upon contemporary racism, her dad mostly tried to get out of the communication. Later, she added:

I think I would have very much liked to actively talk about existing racism and not only about racism in the past. And not to act as if one can say, so to speak: Racism is forbidden, therefore we are not racist.

Similarly, U.S.-based research has documented that white parents rarely discuss racism with their children (Nieri et al., 2024), with conversations about racism limited to distal, publicized events (e.g., BLM) rather than focusing on day-to-day events (e.g., microaggressions or systemic racism) (Cox et al., 2022; Freeman et al., 2022). The tendency to locate racism solely in the past, in right-wing extremism, or abroad allows white Germans to distance themselves from contemporary forms of racism within their own society. This distancing reinforces the myth of a "post-racial" Germany, where racism is seen as an exception rather than a systemic issue.

Importantly, there were also some exceptions of parents who explicitly spoke up against contemporary and more subtle forms of racism. These parents challenged their children when they reproduced racist stereotypes, or intervened when they observed racist incidents in their environment. For example, Lou recalled her mother intervening when a customer of her store used a racial slur against a truck driver and stating that people with racist motives had no business in her store.

"It always depends on where you grow up"—social identities and intergroup contact afford diversity and equity socialization

Our participants generally reported little explicit diversity and equity socialization. However, throughout the interviews we observed important variations in parental socialization which were tied to participants' and their parents' other social identities, as well as to interethnic contact opportunities.

Minoritized social identities promote diversity and equity socialization

Even though the focus of our interviews lay on ERS with regards to participants' privileged social positioning as white, ethnic majority Germans, some participants or their parents occupied a minoritized position with regards to other social identities (e.g., being from a working-class background, being a woman, or being displaced persons). Participants recalled more explicit parental diversity and equity socialization with regards to these identities, e.g., through parents sharing experiences of discrimination or exclusion and preparing children to deal with them—strategies bearing similarities to the "preparation for bias" strategy frequently observed among minoritized ethnic or racialized groups in the U.S. (Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). For example, Franziska recalled her mother finding it important for her to learn how to deal with different cutlery arrangements, with the aim of preparing her for potential biases she might face due to her working-class background: "I think it was simply important to her that I wasn't thrown into a situation where I somehow felt unworthy because of my family history. [...]"

Quite a few participants shared stories of parents' or grandparents' experiences of exclusion due to being displaced persons or migrants as a result of expulsion after the Second World War or of leaving the German Democratic Republic for West Germany. In a few cases, participants and their parents drew connections

between own experiences of exclusion and the situation of other minoritized groups. Sabine recalls:

For example, when the refugee crisis happened. [...] There was always this fear that so many - in quotation marks - foreign people were coming. And then I had to say again, I mean my mother was also of my opinion, that her parents or my grandparents were also refugees and were not welcome here. And what that did to them. And I mean, they spoke the same language. Some of them had the same religion, they came from the same country. And it was still so difficult back in the 1950s.

Intergroup contact promotes diversity and equity socialization

Another pathway that promoted parents' diversity and equity socialization were opportunities for intergroup contact. Most parents, and to a lesser extent, participants themselves, grew up in rather homogeneous environments and had little close interethnic contact, which did not make it seem necessary to discuss issues such as culture, ethnicity, or race. As Max reflected: "Ultimately, I think it always depends on where you grow up. [...] the more you hang out with your equals, your equals in quotation marks, the less you learn about everything else." In contrast, living in a more diverse neighborhood or encountering cultural or ethnic diversity at the workplace promoted parents' sensitivity toward cultural or ethnic diversity and their concurrent socialization strategies. Abigail recalls that growing up in a large, diverse city inspired her parents to engage in diversity socialization:

Well, I mean, when you're out and about in [city], in the city centre, you meet everyone and everything ((laughs)). And it's not just about origin, but also about different people who are somehow homosexual or queer or something, and I think I always asked about that as a child. When I was little. Or if someone had pink hair or, I don't know, darker skin than me or something, I just asked and my parents always answered me very openly [...]. So when I asked about something, it was like this: Yes, we can have a look. Read something about the country or something. And that's why I walk through [city] now and, yes, it's, well, I don't always think: Ah, okay, he's bound to come from there or he's bound to come from there. It's just so normal that they live in Germany.

The parents' workplace was another important context that afforded opportunities for intergroup contact, and consequently, parental diversity and equity socialization. For example, Frieda explained that her mother worked with a lot of people with a family history of

migration, which sparked her interest in issues of racism and inequality.

Along similar lines, previous U.S.-based research found that growing up in a diverse region facilitated more frequent familial discussions about ethnicity and race (Brown et al., 2007). However, in previous research examining parental perspectives on ERS in Germany, parents who lived in a very diverse region reported positive perspectives on diversity, but also reiterated white normativity and established boundaries of belonging (Kaiser et al., 2024). Thus, it is possible that white parent ERS, even in diverse contexts, still often remains on a superficial level.

"There is a big break between the generations"—youth-directed socialization

If discussions around contemporary, more subtle and structural forms of racism occurred in the families, these were usually not driven by the parents, but by the young adults themselves. Thus, we identified a clear pattern of youth-directed socialization (as also observed in U.S.-based research such as Patel et al., 2023).

Young adults initiating conversations about modern, everyday racism

Many participants reported that during adolescence, they barely discussed racism-related topics at home. However, once they grew older, they started initiating discussions with their parents about contemporary racism, including topics such as sensitive language, microaggressions, and structural discrimination. For example, Sabine challenged her parents' use of the N-word:

[...] my one cousin had a Black boyfriend. And of course there was a lot of talk about the N-word. And then I tried to tell them that you don't have to use this word. Because it's just hurtful. Yes, and then they argued, but we have always said that. Yes, but is that an argument, just because I have always said something, I don't have to keep using it if it obviously hurts someone else?

Participants frequently pointed out that awareness and societal norms regarding racism and discrimination had changed in the last few years. The interviews were conducted in late 2021 until spring 2022. Discussions of everyday racism only recently gained more traction in Germany, as an attack on a Jewish synagogue in Halle, Germany, in 2019, a mass shooting of people of immigrant descent in Hanau, Germany, in 2020, and the killings of unarmed Black Americans by police officers inspired demonstrations

against racism all around Germany (della Porta et al., 2023). For many participants, these recent events sparked their own awareness of racism and discrimination. Mia explained:

Well, I would really say that this is how it started with the Black Lives Matter. That we became much more political. Or talked about these issues more. I would also say that social media really had a big influence on my being educated about these issues.

Parental insecurity in a changing society

Parents showed different reactions to youth-directed socialization, ranging from open rejection, to insecurity, to changes in thinking and behavior. When Sabine pointed out to her parents that they should not make generalizations about people with Turkish heritage in Germany, she remembered her mother reacting: “You don’t always have to act as if we’re Nazis.” In some cases though, initial reactions of rejection dissolved over time, as Joana recalls:

First, of course, complete resistance: No, that’s nonsense. Now I’m not allowed to say anything anymore. But then you notice, and I think that’s really wonderful to see, [...]. That in a second conversation, a day later, a week later, they suddenly argue differently. And more in the direction of I think I understand what you mean. And then it’s really renegotiated again and again [...]. Oh, is that still okay or what if I say it like that?

Many participants recalled their parents feeling insecure when discussing contemporary racism. Franziska recalled her mother saying:

That doesn’t work, because you have all these words that you use and I don’t know them. And they are not my words and I don’t know what to do with them and I don’t know the concepts behind them. What, in plain German, do you actually want to tell me?

Similar patterns of parental insecurity with regards to discussing diversity and racism were apparent in white, ethnic majority German parents’ accounts of their ERS in previous research (Kaiser et al., 2025, 2024).

Franziska explained her mother’s feeling of insecurity with generational gaps in working-class families. Through attending university and studying social sciences, she herself became acquainted with terminologies that were unfamiliar to her parents. However, the generational gap pointed out by Franziska was also highlighted by most other participants, including those not from working-class families. Participants explained that their parents grew up in a time when Germany was a less diverse country, and that norms

around discussing racism and discrimination had changed in the last few years, with many things that were more acceptable to say back then not being acceptable anymore today. Pointing out these societal changes often went along with expressing empathy for the parents’ feelings of being overwhelmed. For example, Joana recalls:

I think there is a lot of educational work to be done around the coffee table, when you meet your parents or your family. Because I do believe that there is a big break between the generations. I think everyone has their own wave of novelty that they can keep up with, and at a certain point I think it’s just very exhausting, and there are just a lot of people in my family who say, ‘Whew, I’m not quite keeping up’.

The generational differences we observed reflect broader societal shifts in Germany, where younger generations are increasingly engaging with issues of social justice (Albert et al., 2019). Youth-directed socialization offers a pathway for fostering critical engagement with racism also among older generations, but it also underscores the need for intergenerational dialogue and mutual learning to bridge these differences and promote inclusivity.

General discussion

We explored white, ethnic majority German young adults’ accounts of parental socialization around race, ethnicity, culture, and national identity. Based on a codebook thematic analysis, we developed five overarching themes: (1) *Perceived culture- and race-less socialization*; (2) *preaching but not practicing egalitarianism*; (3) *distancing from racism*; (4) *social identities and intergroup contact afford equity and diversity socialization*; and (5) *youth-directed socialization*. The findings expose a gap between the broader socialization goals upheld by white, ethnic majority German parents and their application in a dynamically evolving society. The overall lack of explicit socialization by white, ethnic majority parents around race and racism, ethnicity, and culture (see *perceived culture and race-less socialization* and *distancing from racism* themes), as well as the shallow focus on egalitarianism (see *preaching but not practicing egalitarianism* theme) mirror previous research findings on white parent ERS in the U.S. (Aral et al., 2022; Loyd & Gaither, 2018; Nieri et al., 2024; Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024; Priest et al., 2014; Simon, 2021) and Germany (Kaiser et al., 2025, 2024). However, similar as in the U.S. (Gillen-O’Neel et al., 2022), some participants, particularly those in more diverse environments, also recalled their parents to engage in explicit anti-racist

or diversity socialization. Beyond these similarities, our study also revealed some additional context-specific and theoretical insights.

Context-specific insights

As discussed in our *perceived culture and race-less socialization* theme, very few of our participants remembered their parents ever discussing the meaning of being white, and even in these cases, this was done without explicitly naming whiteness. Compared to U.S.-based research, the taboo surrounding the term “Rasse” in Germany further complicated reflections on the meaning of whiteness for our participants and their parents. At the same time, some participants’ accounts revealed an implicit equation of being German with being white and celebrating Christian traditions, highlighting exclusionary, racialized narratives of national belonging. This emphasizes the importance of considering variations with regards to the meaning and usage of socially constructed categories when examining ERS in different contexts.

Participants also struggled defining German culture and perceived little German culture socialization. In the U.S., white parents tend to avoid discussing the meaning of being white due to negative connotations of “white pride,” which may make ethnicity a more comfortable space to explore (Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024). Particularly among our rather left-leaning sample, not only whiteness, but also German ethnicity and national identity were uncomfortable spaces to explore with parents, which may be partly traced back to feelings of transgenerational guilt felt by some Germans toward the country’s past (Seiffge-Krenke & Haid, 2012). Whereas highlighting that ethnic majority Germans also “have a culture” may be important, promoting ethnic majority cultural socialization in a context with a clear ethnic majority group may also reinforce exclusionary narratives of national belonging. Currently, right-wing movements in Germany are calling for a reduced emphasis on Germany’s historical guilt and a strengthening of German identity, limiting this identity to those perceived as white ethnic majority German (Schareika, 2016). To counter these exclusionary narratives, it is crucial to rewrite “Germanness” as not based on ethnic homogeneity, but on common democratic values and diversity (Foroutan, 2019). Such a redefinition may not only foster more inclusive national belonging but also support white, ethnic majority German youth in developing identities that align with anti-racist and

democratic principles, enabling them to contribute to a more equitable society.

Our *distancing from racism* theme showed that participants’ parents typically discussed racism as something rather distanced from themselves and their own family. Even though similar notions have been identified in U.S.-based research (Cox et al., 2022; Freeman et al., 2022), in Germany, parents drew on additional distancing strategies, by limiting racism to something occurring during a specific time in the past (i.e. during the Holocaust) or abroad (mainly in the U.S.). Despite Germany’s strong remembrance culture around the Holocaust, which has been deemed by some to constitute a role model for dealing with past crimes (Neiman, 2019), this remembrance culture does not include other periods of Germany’s racist history (e.g., colonialism) and does not seem to translate into an awareness of contemporary, everyday forms of racism. Thus, examining parent ERS in different contexts needs to take into account how past and current racism is dealt with in a particular socio-historical context.

Theoretical insights

White, ethnic majority young adults as active agents of ERS

Even though ERS is theoretically conceptualized to be a bidirectional process (Hughes et al., 2006), most research on ERS focuses on adult initiation and youth reception (Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024). By interviewing white, ethnic majority young adults about their retrospective accounts of parent ERS, we found that youth not only interpreted and reflected on their parents’ messages, but also actively initiated ERS processes. As discussed in our *youth-directed socialization* theme, young adults initiated discussions on systemic and subtle, contemporary forms of racism, such as micro-aggressions. This finding connects to and expands recent insights on adolescent-directed ERS among minoritized families. Adolescents from Asian American and Latinx immigrant families in the U.S. receive more messages on the racial landscape from the broader society (i.e. social media, peers, school) than their parents which may lead them to become the deliverers of ERS messages (Patel et al., 2023; Young et al., 2021). Our study adds to this research by showing that white, ethnic majority young adults also act as deliverers of ERS messages.

The young adults’ retrospective accounts revealed that youth-directed socialization typically began after adolescence. This delay may reflect developmental

changes, as young adulthood often involves consciousness-raising experiences, such as exposure to new social environments and college coursework (Umaña-Taylor et al., 2014). It may also stem from recent societal shifts that have heightened awareness of subtle and structural forms of racism. Either way, considering youth-directed socialization is crucial as it may have cascading, intergenerational impacts, for example by influencing participants' parents' own critical consciousness of racism, which may in turn feed back into ERS processes (Patel et al., 2023), as well as by altering how the participants' themselves may engage in ERS with the next generation. Overall, our findings highlight the necessity to view ERS as a dynamic interaction between individuals and their environments, where young adults are not merely passive recipients but active agents of change (Hagerman, 2016; Perry et al., 2024).

Intersectionality in white, ethnic majority ERS

Even though the initial focus of our study lay on participants' social categorization as white, ethnic majority Germans, other social identities were also relevant for ERS processes. First, as evident in our theme *social identities and intergroup contact afford diversity and equity socialization*, many participants occupied minoritized social identities, such as being women, being from a lower social class, or having parents or grandparents who were displaced persons, and received more explicit diversity and equity socialization with regards to these identities, which was sometimes translated into their understanding of ethnic-racial diversity. Second, social class may have influenced parents' exposure to and use of contemporary terminology regarding race and racism.

Limitations and future directions

The current study is one of only few studies on ERS in Germany, and highlighted the young adults' perspectives on their parents' ERS. However, it also has some limitations. Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, interviews were conducted via Zoom, which may have affected the level of trust and rapport between interviewer and participants. Even though the participants' parents had diverse educational backgrounds, most of our participants themselves had an academic school diploma and were currently studying for their bachelor's or master's degrees, often in education or social sciences, through which many of them had had formal opportunities to learn about and reflect on social inequality. Different patterns of ERS may be observed

among participants with different educational backgrounds. Although political ideology was not formally assessed, many participants expressed left-leaning views, which may have shaped their interpretations of ERS. Including measures of political ideology in future studies could help disentangle its role in ERS perceptions. As the majority of our sample was from West Germany, the marginalization experienced by East Germans and its consequences for ERS may have remained underexplored. In addition, whereas in this paper we focused on parents as socialization agents, these did not constitute the only sources of ERS. Peers and social media often came up during the interviews as additional, relevant socialization agents, but a detailed analysis of peer and social media ERS was beyond the scope of this paper.

Our analysis suggests several directions for future research: First, future research could delve more deeply into white, ethnic majority adolescents' role as not just receivers, but active agents of ERS. Second, studies should take into account white, ethnic majority adolescents' other social identities (e.g., gender, social class) and their implications for ERS processes (for a similar suggestion, see Perry, Abaied, et al., 2024). Among others, this research could examine under what conditions own experiences of exclusion (e.g., based on gender, social class) may be translated into increased critical awareness of others' experiences of exclusion (e.g., based on ethnicity or race). Third, research on white, ethnic majority ERS should expand its focus from families toward additional socialization settings, such as peers and social media (Dull et al., 2022; Hughes et al., 2016). Fourth, based on successful ERS interventions developed for white parents in the U.S. (Perry, Wu, et al., 2024), similar interventions could be developed for other societal contexts such as Germany.

Even though the recent gains made by right-wing parties in Europe among younger voters are cause for concern, the fact that many of our participants experienced more exposure to diversity and higher awareness of racism than their parents may also allow a positive outlook. To use the words of one of our participants, Joana:

But I also believe, and I think this is the take-away message, that communication in the families and communication in the broadening of horizons is only really happening now. [...]. Because so much has happened in Germany in the last century that I think the Germans were so preoccupied with themselves and somehow blindly followed the label: There is no more racism, therefore we don't need to talk about it. As I said, that's no excuse, [...]. But I think we are slowly but surely on the right track.

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Ethical approval

This study was approved by the University of Potsdam Research Ethics Committee (approval no. 84/2020) on January 21, 2021.

Informed consent

All participants provided written informed consent prior to participating.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

AI statement

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Data availability statement

The datasets generated during and/or analyzed during the current study are not publicly available since the informed consent form stated that only the researchers have access to the data.

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